THE MATERNITY METHOD

NCLEX CHEAT SHEET

Newborn Care

Maternal & Newborn › Newborn

The Big Picture The first hours are about **transition**: baby has to start **breathing**, **stay warm**, and keep **blood sugar** up. Then it's head-to-toe assessment, **meds and screenings**, and teaching parents to care for baby safely at home.

KNOW THE NUMBERS

110–160	30–60	36.5–37.5 °C	2,500–4,000 g	7–10%
Heart rate (bpm)	**Resp rate** (breaths/min)	**Axillary** temp	Normal **birth weight**	Max **weight loss**; regained by 10–14 days

APGAR Score

At 1 and 5 minutes · **7–10 = good**, 4–6 = needs help, 0–3 = resuscitate

Sign	0	1	2
Appearance (color)	Blue or pale all over	Pink body, **blue hands/feet**	Pink all over
Pulse	Absent	< 100	**≥ 100**
Grimace (reflex)	No response	Grimace	Cry, cough, sneeze
Activity (tone)	Limp	Some flexion	**Active** movement
Respirations	Absent	Slow, irregular, weak cry	**Strong cry**

MEMORY HACK · HEAT LOSS

Baby loses heat 4 ways: "Every Cold Crib Robs"

Evaporation
wet skin → **dry right away**

Conduction
cold surfaces → **warm scale**, skin-to-skin

Convection
drafts → **hat**, away from vents/doors

Radiation
cold walls/windows → crib **away from windows**

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Newborn Meds & Screens

What	Why	Nurse must-know
Vitamin K (IM)	Newborn gut has no bacteria to make vitamin K → **bleeding** risk	**Vastus lateralis**, in the first hours
Erythromycin eye ointment	Prevents eye infection from **gonorrhea**	Both eyes, within 1–2 hrs; don't wipe off right away
Hepatitis B vaccine	Starts lifelong protection	Within **24 hrs**; add **HBIG within 12 hrs** if mom is HBsAg+
Metabolic blood spot (PKU, etc.)	Finds rare but treatable disorders	After **24 hrs** of age and after feeding; heel stick (outer heel)
Hearing screen	Early hearing-loss detection	Before discharge
Heart (CCHD) pulse ox	Finds critical heart defects	After 24 hrs, **right hand + a foot**; pass = **≥ 95%** and **≤ 3%** apart

Normal: Reassure Parents

- **Acrocyanosis** (blue hands/feet) in the first days
- **Molding**, **caput** (swelling that **crosses** sutures)
- **Milia**, **erythema toxicum** (newborn rash), **vernix**, lanugo
- **Mongolian spots**: blue-gray patches; **document** them
- Swollen breasts, **pseudomenstruation**
- **Epstein pearls** on the gums/palate

Report These

- **Central cyanosis**, grunting, retractions
- **Jaundice < 24 hrs**
- **Cephalohematoma** (doesn't cross sutures) → watch for **jaundice**
- **Bulging** or **sunken** fontanel
- No **urine** in 24 hrs or no **meconium** in 48 hrs
- Temp **unstable**, poor feeding, lethargy

Head & Reflexes

- **Head** 33–35 cm; **chest** about 2 cm smaller
- **Anterior fontanel** (diamond) closes **12–18 mo**
- **Posterior fontanel** (triangle) closes **by 2–3 mo**
- **Moro**, rooting, sucking, **grasp**, stepping, **tonic neck**: present at birth
- **Babinski** (toes fan out) is **normal** until about age 1

Parent Teaching

- **Safe sleep: on the back**, firm flat surface, **nothing** in the crib, room-share
- **Rear-facing** car seat
- **Feeds** 8–12×/day; **6+ wet diapers** a day by day 5–6
- **Cord:** keep **dry**, diaper folded below; falls off in 10–14 days
- **Circumcision:** petroleum jelly; **yellow crust** is normal; report bleeding or no urine
- **Bulb syringe:** mouth **before** nose

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RED FLAGS · STOP AND CALL THE PROVIDER

HR **< 100** or RR **> 60** with distress · **Central cyanosis** · Temp **< 36.5 °C** that won't come up · **Jaundice in first 24 hrs** · **Seizures**, very floppy tone · **Bleeding** from cord or circumcision

MUST-KNOW FOR THE NCLEX

- **APGAR at 1 and 5 min.** 7–10 is reassuring.
- **Vitamin K** (vastus lateralis), **erythromycin** eyes, **Hep B** vaccine: know the why for each.
- **Caput crosses** suture lines; **cephalohematoma doesn't** and raises jaundice risk.
- **Back to sleep**, nothing in the crib.
- **Acrocyanosis is normal**; central cyanosis is not.

QUICK CHECK · TEST YOURSELF

1. Vitamin K is given IM in the _____ muscle.
2. A baby is pink with blue hands and feet, HR 140, cries, active, strong cry: APGAR = ___.
3. Swelling that does NOT cross suture lines is a _____.
4. The posterior fontanel closes by about ___ months.
5. Baby placed on a cold scale loses heat by _____.

Answers: 1. vastus lateralis · 2. 9 · 3. cephalohematoma · 4. 2–3 · 5. conduction

For study use only. Always follow facility protocols, current guidelines, and provider orders.

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